

A White Heron

Sarah Orne Jewett · 1886

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TEACHER EDITION · CURRICULUM UNIT

One 90-minute lesson (the whole story), with an optional take-home essay

Syllabus · 90-minute lesson plans · lecture scripts · vocabulary · quizzes with keys · writing prompts at eleven rigor levels · SAT-style items · whole-book test · essays

Liber et Libri · Lux et Libri LLC

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Contents and unit overview

1. Unit overview and the 90-minute lesson
2. Syllabus (weekly pacing)
3. Lesson plans and lecture scripts (chapters 1–1), each with vocabulary, discussion questions, annotation focus, quiz and key, writing prompts and SAT-style items
4. Whole-book test and answer key
5. Essay assignments at eleven rigor levels

Edition: Reading text: https://en.wikisource.org/wiki/A_White_Heron (revision 15592539), cleaned for Liber et Libri.

Grades: Grades 7–11 (scales to graduate via rigor levels). Short story: read whole in one 90-minute lesson (assign longer stories as pre-reading). Middle School prompts use the full text when the grade tags include 6–8; otherwise teacher-selected passages. **Weeks:** 1. **Class days:** 1 × 90 minutes (1 chapter lessons plus seminar, test and essay days).

Essential questions

- What does A White Heron suggest about nature versus progress?
- What does A White Heron suggest about loyalty and silence?
- What does A White Heron suggest about girlhood?

Objectives

- Cite textual evidence to support analysis of what the text says explicitly and implicitly.
- Determine themes and analyze their development over the course of the story.
- Analyze how characters, setting and point of view interact.
- Determine the meaning of words and phrases as they are used in the text.
- Write arguments to support claims with clear reasons and relevant evidence.

Standards and frameworks

- **Common Core:** RL.7.2, RL.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2, RL.9-10.3, RL.9-10.4, RL.9-10.5, RL.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2, RL.11-12.4, RL.11-12.5, W.7.1, W.9-10.1, W.11-12.1, L.9-10.4, L.11-12.4
  Common Core State Standards (ELA-Literacy), thecorestandards.org
- **Indiana 2023:** 7.RC.2, 7.RC.3, 7.W.1, 9-10.RC.1, 9-10.RC.2, 9-10.RC.3, 9-10.RC.9, 9-10.RC.12, 9-10.W.1, 11-12.RC.1, 11-12.RC.3, 11-12.RC.4, 11-12.RC.11, 11-12.RC.13, 11-12.W.1
  Indiana Academic Standards, English/Language Arts (2023), IDOE

- **Dual Credit (Indiana College Core):** ICC-WC-1.1, ICC-WC-1.3, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.7
  Indiana College Core, Written Communication outcomes 1.1–1.7 (CHE guidance); ICC-WC-x IDs are ours
- **AP:** AP-LIT.CHR, AP-LIT.SET, AP-LIT.STR, AP-LIT.NAR, AP-LIT.FIG, AP-LIT.LAN
  AP English Literature and Composition big ideas (our summaries; apcentral.collegeboard.org)
- **Cambridge International:** CAIE-9695.AO1, CAIE-9695.AO2, CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4, CAIE-9695.AO5
  Cambridge International AS & A Level Literature in English 9695 assessment objectives (our summaries; cambridgeinternational.org)
- **Liber et Libri program outcomes:** LeL-C2-LIT-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1
  Liber et Libri program outcome, not an official standard

Primary codes: RL.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2, RL.9-10.3, RL.9-10.4, RL.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2, RL.11-12.5, W.9-10.1, W.11-12.1, RL.7.2
Assessments: Daily story quizzes (auto-graded); Weekly writing prompt (rubric); Socratic seminars (scheduled days); Whole-story test (scheduled day); Final essay (scheduled day); College Sophomore and above write one essay of the five
Differentiation: Every prompt and quiz has eleven rigor levels (Middle School through Graduate / PhD); the app applies student override, then class standard, then the automatic level. Each prompt is tagged for Common Core, Indiana 2023, Dual Credit (Indiana College Core), AP and Cambridge where they apply.
Materials: Liber et Libri reader; Annotation journal; Story lecture slides or script

The 90-minute lesson

#	Segment	Mode	Minutes	Clock
1	Bell-ringer	You do	8	0–8
2	Vocabulary with etymology notes	I do	10	8–18
3	Background and context	I do	10	18–28
4	I do: modeled close reading	I do	12	28–40
5	We do: guided annotation	We do	15	40–55
6	You do: independent annotation	You do	15	55–70
7	Discussion	We do	10	70–80
8	Exit ticket / chapter quiz	You do	7	80–87
9	Closure	I do	3	87–90
	Total		**90**	

Syllabus

Week	Chapters	Lessons	Focus and activities	Assessment
1	A White Heron	1 × 90 min (90 min)	*nature versus progress* • Daily 90-minute lesson: bell-ringer, vocabulary and word histories, background, I do / We do / You do, discussion, exit ticket, closure • Story quizzes in the app • Writing prompt at assigned rigor (one graded per week)	Quiz average plus one graded writing prompt

Lesson plans and lecture scripts

Each chapter is one 90-minute class. Scripts are a starting point; adapt them to your students. Teacher summaries contain spoilers.

Lesson 1: A White Heron

Focus: a girl choosing nature over a stranger's approval

Content note (shooting of birds): Sensitive content: Shooting of birds. Preview the story, tell students in advance, and allow a pass on reading aloud. Keep discussion on how the writer uses these elements, not on graphic detail.
Student preview: Heads-up: this story includes shooting of birds.
Suggested language: "Why does the writer include this, and what does it make us notice?"

Teacher only · spoilers

Nine-year-old Sylvia, who lives with her grandmother on a Maine farm, meets a young ornithologist hunting a rare white heron to shoot and stuff. He offers ten dollars for its location. At dawn Sylvia climbs a giant pine and sees the heron's nest. She returns but will not tell; the hunter leaves, and the narrator wonders what she lost and gained.

Background: Published in 1886, when plume hunting for women's hats was devastating heron populations; the Audubon movement began the same decade.

Significance: A Common Core Appendix B 11–CCR exemplar and a central regionalist text.

Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Respond in writing to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
Settle in and write for five minutes: Would you keep a secret to protect something you love, even if it cost you? No wrong answers yet; we will test these ideas against the text. Two volunteers share, and I note key words on the board. Before we start, a content note: Heads-up: this story includes shooting of birds.

8–18 min · Vocabulary with etymology notes · I do (10 min)
Introduce 5 key words: pronounce, define from context, then the word's history.
Today's words are fretfully, dilatory, elusive, loitered, provoking. For each one we read the sentence, guess from context and then check the definition. Here is the first: "But Sylvia does not speak after all, though the old grandmother fretfully rebukes her, and the young man's kind, appealing eyes are looking straight in her own." In this sentence it means: in an irritable, complaining way. Word histories: For the other words, look up the word history (Etymonline or the OED) and record the language of origin and the root meaning in your etymology log.

18–28 min · Background and context · I do (10 min)
Present the historical and literary background.
Here is what the first readers of A White Heron would have known. Published in 1886, when plume hunting for women's hats was devastating heron populations; the Audubon movement began the same decade. Why does this story matter? A Common Core Appendix B 11–CCR exemplar and a central regionalist text. Write down one question you want answered.

28–40 min · I do: modeled close reading · I do (12 min)
Teacher models a think-aloud on the anchor passage for setting.
Watch me read this the way a careful reader does. The passage opens: "The woods were already filled with shadows one June evening, just before eight o'clock, though a bright sunset still glimmered faintly among the trunks of the trees." I stop and ask: what is the author doing here, and how does it connect to a girl choosing nature over a stranger's approval? I circle "dilatory", one of today's words, and ask why the author chose it over a plainer word. When I find setting, I underline it and write its effect in the margin, then I check my idea against the next sentence.

40–55 min · We do: guided annotation · We do (15 min)
Read the anchor passage aloud together; annotate for setting.
Now we do it together. I read the first sentence and you track along. Mark every example of setting. Turn to a partner: what does the author want us to notice? I will collect three ideas and we choose the strongest using evidence.

> *The woods were already filled with shadows one June evening, just before eight o'clock, though a bright sunset still glimmered faintly among the trunks of the trees. A little girl was driving home her cow, a plodding, dilatory, provoking creature in her behavior, but a valued companion for all that. They were going away from whatever light there was, and striking deep into the woods, but their feet were familiar with the path, and it was no matter whether their eyes could see it or not.*

55–70 min · You do: independent annotation · You do (15 min)
Students annotate a new passage independently in the reader, then begin the writing prompt at their assigned rigor level.
Your turn. Annotate the next page in the app for Setting, Symbolism, Point of view: at least three marks with a margin note each. Then open your writing prompt; the app shows the level your teacher assigned (for a 9–10 class, the HS Sophomore prompt reads: Analyze how A White Heron develops the idea of a girl choosing nature over a stranger's approval. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of setting and symbolism shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.) I will circulate and conference.

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)
Structured discussion from the 30 tiered questions (focus set for the class level): wait time, think-pair-share on DOK 3/4, follow-up probes.
Let's talk. We move from what happens to why it matters to whether it's right. After each question I wait before calling on anyone: think first. Our anchor question: How does this story connect to nature versus progress? Every claim needs a page reference. Respond to the person before you by agreeing, extending or challenging with evidence, and end by writing one question of your own.

80–87 min · Exit ticket / chapter quiz · You do (7 min)
Story quiz in the app, then a one-sentence exit ticket.
Take the story quiz in the app. Then, in one sentence, tell me what this story suggests about a girl choosing nature over a stranger's approval, backed by one short quotation.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)
Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
Today we saw how setting shapes a girl choosing nature over a stranger's approval. Tonight, read the next story and add two words to your etymology log.

Total: 90 minutes.

Vocabulary with etymology notes

Word	Definition (in this sentence)	In context	Word history
fretfully (adverb)	in an irritable, complaining way	*But Sylvia does not speak after all, though the old grandmother fretfully rebukes her, and the young man's kind, appealing eyes are looking straight in her own.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
dilatory (adjective)	slow; tending to delay	*A little girl was driving home her cow, a plodding, dilatory, provoking creature in her behavior, but a valued companion for all that.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
elusive (adjective)	hard to grasp, catch or put into words	*She grieved because the longed-for white heron was elusive, but she did not lead the guest, she only followed, and there was no such thing as speaking first.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
loitered (verb)	lingered; hung about	*The good woman suspected that Sylvia loitered occasionally on her own account; there never was such a child for straying about out-of-doors since the world was made!*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
provoking (verb)	call forth (emotions, feelings, and responses)	*A little girl was driving home her cow, a plodding, dilatory, provoking creature in her behavior, but a valued companion for all that.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
homeward (adjective)	oriented toward home	*Though this chase had been so long that the wary animal herself had given an unusual signal of her whereabouts, Sylvia had only laughed when she came upon Mistress Moolly at the swamp-side, and urged her affectionately homeward with a twig of birch leaves.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
triumphant (adjective)	joyful and proud especially because of triumph or success	*Sylvia's face was like a pale star, if one had seen it from the ground, when the last thorny bough was past, and she stood trembling and tired but wholly triumphant, high in the tree-top.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
awakened (verb)	stirred up	*"Dear sakes, yes," responded the hostess, whose long slumbering hospitality seemed to be easily awakened. "You might fare better if you went out to the main road a mile or so, but you're welcome to what we've got.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
valuable (adjective)	useful; worth having	*Tilley had chased the hornéd torment too many summer evenings herself to blame any one else for lingering, and was only thankful as she waited that she had Sylvia, nowadays, to give such valuable assistance.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)

compassion (noun)	a deep awareness of and sympathy for another's suffering	*She thought often with wistful compassion of a wretched geranium that belonged to a town neighbor.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)

Discussion questions

1. Would you keep a secret to protect something you love, even if it cost you?
2. Where does setting appear in this story, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.
3. How does this story connect to the book's larger concern with nature versus progress?

Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Middle School: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

Literal / recall

1. Whom does Sylvia live with? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: Her grandmother, Mrs. Tilley
2. What is the hunter looking for? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: A white heron
3. What does he offer for information? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: Ten dollars
4. How does Sylvia find the nest? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: She climbs a great pine tree at dawn
5. What does Sylvia decide? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: Not to tell the hunter
6. Retell the three most important events of "A White Heron" in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: Nine-year-old Sylvia, who lives with her grandmother on a Maine farm, meets a young ornithologist hunting a rare white heron to shoot and stuff. He offers ten dollars for its location. At dawn Sylvia climbs a giant pine and sees the heron's nest. She returns but will not tell; the hunter leaves, and the narrator wonders what she lost and gained.
7. Which characters appear or are mentioned in "A White Heron"? Name two and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: Names and actions taken from the story; check against the teacher summary.
8. Where and when does "A White Heron" take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the story.
9. Reread: "But Sylvia does not speak after all, though the old grandmother fretfully rebukes her, and the young man's kind, appealing eyes are looking straight in her own." What does "fretfully" mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: fretfully: in an irritable, complaining way.

10. Reread: “A little girl was driving home her cow, a plodding, dilatory, provoking creature in her behavior, but a valued companion for all that.” What does “dilatory” mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: dilatory: slow; tending to delay.

Inferential / analytical

1. What does “A White Heron” suggest about a girl choosing nature over a stranger's approval? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.2] Look for: A Common Core Appendix B 11–CCR exemplar and a central regionalist text.
2. Find one example of setting in this story. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: Look for where and when events happen and how place shapes action or feeling.
3. How does the symbolism in this story shape what we understand about a girl choosing nature over a stranger's approval? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.4, SL.7.1, 7.RC.12, 7.CC.2] Look for: Look for objects, places or actions that stand for larger ideas.
4. In the passage that begins “The woods were already filled with shadows one June evening, just before eight o'clock, though a bright sunset still glimmered faintly among the trunks of the trees.”, why might Jewett have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.4, SL.7.1, 7.RC.12, 7.CC.2] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.
5. What causes the main turn in “A White Heron”, and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: Nine-year-old Sylvia, who lives with her grandmother on a Maine farm, meets a young ornithologist hunting a rare white heron to shoot and stuff. He offers ten dollars for its location. At dawn Sylvia climbs a giant pine and sees the heron's nest. She returns but will not tell; the hunter leaves,…
6. As the opening story, what does “A White Heron” set up that the rest of A White Heron will need? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous story.
7. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say and do here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.
8. The bell-ringer asked: “Would you keep a secret to protect something you love, even if it cost you?” Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.2] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.
9. Where does point of view appear, and how does it connect this story to the larger concern with nature versus progress? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.7.6, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.2] Look for: Look for who is telling the story and what that narrator can and cannot know.
10. Background: Published in 1886, when plume hunting for women's hats was devastating heron populations; the Audubon movement began the same decade. How does knowing this change the way you read one moment in the story? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: A specific moment reread in light of the context.

Evaluative / synthesis / creative

1. A critic might argue: "A Common Core Appendix B 11–CCR exemplar and a central regionalist text." How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the story. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.
2. Which character in this story acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.3] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.
3. Rewrite one moment of "A White Heron" from the point of view of a different character. What does the new angle reveal or hide about a girl choosing nature over a stranger's approval? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.6, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.3] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.
4. Write three questions of your own about "A White Heron": one recall, one "why/how", and one "should/what if". Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.
5. Connect this story to loyalty and silence: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Jewett need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.
6. Is the setting in this story effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.3] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.
7. Compare how "A White Heron" treats a girl choosing nature over a stranger's approval with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does A White Heron see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.
8. As the final story, does this ending resolve nature versus progress? Argue whether the ending is earned. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.3] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.
9. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this story (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about a girl choosing nature over a stranger's approval? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.
10. What question would you most like to ask Sarah Orne Jewett about this story, and what answer do you think the text itself gives? [DOK 4 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A student-generated question answered from evidence.

Annotation focus

- **Setting:** look for where and when events happen and how place shapes action or feeling (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Symbolism**: objects, places or actions that stand for larger ideas
- Also notice **Point of view**: who is telling the story and what that narrator can and cannot know

Chapter quiz

1. Whom does Sylvia live with?

   A. The hunter

B. Her grandmother, Mrs. Tilley

C. Her parents

D. Her aunt

2. What is the hunter looking for?

A. Gold

B. A white heron

C. A deer

D. A lost cow

3. What does he offer for information?

A. A book

B. A gun

C. Ten dollars

D. A ride to town

4. How does Sylvia find the nest?

A. She climbs a great pine tree at dawn

B. She follows the hunter

C. The cow leads her

D. Her grandmother tells her

5. What does Sylvia decide?

A. Not to tell the hunter

B. To shoot the bird

C. To show him the nest

D. To leave home

6. In the line "But Sylvia does not speak after all, though the old grandmother fretfully rebukes her, and the young man's kind, appealing eyes are looking straight in her own.", what does "fretfully" most nearly mean?

A. in an irritable, complaining way

B. lingered; hung about

C. slow; tending to delay

D. hard to grasp, catch or put into words

7. In the line "A little girl was driving home her cow, a plodding, dilatory, provoking creature in her behavior, but a valued companion for all that.", what does "dilatory" most nearly mean?

A. in an irritable, complaining way

B. slow; tending to delay

C. lingered; hung about

D. hard to grasp, catch or put into words

Answer key: 1. B (Her grandmother, Mrs. Tilley); 2. B (A white heron); 3. C (Ten dollars); 4. A (She climbs a great pine tree at dawn); 5. A (Not to tell the hunter); 6. A (in an irritable, complaining way); 7. B (slow; tending to delay)

Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)

Middle School (250 words; Common Core: RL.7.3, W.7.1; Indiana 2023: 7.RC.3, 7.W.1): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track; this story is above the grades 6–8 complexity band, so work from the passage your teacher selects). In “A White Heron,” how does Jewett show a girl choosing nature over a stranger's approval? Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the setting you noticed as one piece of evidence.

HS Freshman (350 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1; Indiana 2023: 9-10.RC.1, 9-10.W.1): In A White Heron, how does Jewett develop the idea of a girl choosing nature over a stranger's approval? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the setting in the story helps build that idea.

HS Sophomore (450 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1; Indiana 2023: 9-10.RC.1, 9-10.W.1): Analyze how A White Heron develops the idea of a girl choosing nature over a stranger's approval. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of setting and symbolism shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

HS Junior (550 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, RL.11-12.1, W.11-12.1; Indiana 2023: 11-12.RC.3, 11-12.RC.1, 11-12.W.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2, CAIE-9695.AO3): Analyze how the structure of A White Heron (where it begins, turns and ends) and its setting shape the reader's understanding of a girl choosing nature over a stranger's approval. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning.

HS Senior (600 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.3, W.11-12.1; Indiana 2023: 11-12.RC.1, 11-12.W.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO5): Two readers disagree about what A White Heron suggests about a girl choosing nature over a stranger's approval. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the story's setting and symbolism), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay.

AP (650 words; AP: AP-LIT.SET, AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: RL.11-12.3, W.11-12.1; Indiana 2023: 11-12.RC.1, 11-12.W.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how Sarah Orne Jewett uses setting in A White Heron to complicate the reader's understanding of a girl choosing nature over a stranger's approval. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

College Freshman (1000 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.3, ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.1): Situate A White Heron within its historical and literary context and argue how the story's treatment of a girl choosing nature over a stranger's approval responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

College Sophomore (1250 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-LIT-1, LeL-C2-W-1): Read A White Heron alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the story's handling of a girl choosing nature over a stranger's approval follows or bends those conventions, using the setting as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

College Junior (1500 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-LIT-1, LeL-C3-W-1): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to A White Heron and its treatment of a girl choosing nature over a stranger's approval. State your method, show what it reveals in the story's setting and symbolism, and identify where the text resists it.

College Senior (2000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-LIT-1, LeL-C4-W-1): Develop a research argument that reads A White Heron as evidence for a larger claim about a girl choosing nature over a stranger's approval in A White Heron. Connect close reading of the story to the whole story, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

Graduate / PhD (2500 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-LIT-1, LeL-GR-W-1): Develop an original argument that reads A White Heron as a hinge in the story's larger treatment of a girl choosing nature over a stranger's approval. Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on A White Heron.

SAT-style questions

1. *She grieved because the longed-for white heron was elusive, but she did not lead the guest, she only followed, and there was no such thing as speaking first.*

   As used in the text, what does the word “elusive” most nearly mean?

   A. useful; worth having

   B. stirred up

   C. a deep awareness of and sympathy for another's suffering

   D. hard to grasp, catch or put into words

2. *The woods were already filled with shadows one June evening, just before eight o'clock, though a bright sunset still glimmered faintly among the trunks of the trees. A little girl was driving home her cow, a plodding, dilatory, provoking creature in her behavior, but a valued companion for all that. They were going away from whatever light there was, and striking deep into the woods, but their feet were familiar with the path, and it was no matter whether their eyes could see it or not.*

   Which choice best states a central concern of “A White Heron”?

   A. The foolishness of wishing to be young again

   B. Racial pride destroying love

   C. A girl choosing nature over a stranger's approval

   D. What fifteen years of solitude teach

SAT key: 1. D (hard to grasp, catch or put into words); 2. C (A girl choosing nature over a stranger's approval)

Whole-book test

A White Heron: whole-book test · 90 minutes

Part I: Multiple choice

1. Whom does Sylvia live with?
   A. The hunter
   B. Her grandmother, Mrs. Tilley
   C. Her parents
   D. Her aunt
2. What is the hunter looking for?
   A. Gold
   B. A white heron
   C. A deer
   D. A lost cow
3. What does he offer for information?
   A. A book
   B. A gun
   C. Ten dollars
   D. A ride to town
4. How does Sylvia find the nest?
   A. She climbs a great pine tree at dawn
   B. She follows the hunter
   C. The cow leads her
   D. Her grandmother tells her
5. What does Sylvia decide?
   A. Not to tell the hunter
   B. To shoot the bird
   C. To show him the nest
   D. To leave home
6. In the line “But Sylvia does not speak after all, though the old grandmother fretfully rebukes her, and the young man's kind, appealing eyes are looking straight in her own.”, what does “fretfully” most nearly mean?
   A. in an irritable, complaining way
   B. lingered; hung about
   C. slow; tending to delay
   D. hard to grasp, catch or put into words

7. In the line “A little girl was driving home her cow, a plodding, dilatory, provoking creature in her behavior, but a valued companion for all that.”, what does “dilatory” most nearly mean?
   A. in an irritable, complaining way
   B. slow; tending to delay
   C. lingered; hung about
   D. hard to grasp, catch or put into words
8. As used in the story (“But Sylvia does not speak after all, though the old grandmother fretfully rebukes her, and the young man's kind, appealing eyes are looking ”), what does “fretfully” mean?
   A. in an irritable, complaining way
   B. call forth (emotions, feelings, and responses)
   C. stirred up
   D. slow; tending to delay
9. As used in the story (“A little girl was driving home her cow, a plodding, dilatory, provoking creature in her behavior, but a valued companion for all that.”), what does “dilatory” mean?
   A. oriented toward home
   B. slow; tending to delay
   C. useful; worth having
   D. hard to grasp, catch or put into words
10. As used in the story (“She grieved because the longed-for white heron was elusive, but she did not lead the guest, she only followed, and there was no such thing a”), what does “elusive” mean?
    A. joyful and proud especially because of triumph or success
    B. a deep awareness of and sympathy for another's suffering
    C. hard to grasp, catch or put into words
    D. lingered; hung about
11. As used in the story (“The good woman suspected that Sylvia loitered occasionally on her own account; there never was such a child for straying about out-of-doors ”), what does “loitered” mean?
    A. stirred up
    B. in an irritable, complaining way
    C. call forth (emotions, feelings, and responses)
    D. lingered; hung about
12. As used in the story (“A little girl was driving home her cow, a plodding, dilatory, provoking creature in her behavior, but a valued companion for all that.”), what does “provoking” mean?
    A. call forth (emotions, feelings, and responses)
    B. useful; worth having
    C. slow; tending to delay
    D. oriented toward home

Part II: Short answer

1. Explain how nature versus progress develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.

2. Explain how loyalty and silence develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.
3. Explain how girlhood develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.

Part III: Essay

Choose one of the story's central concerns (nature versus progress, loyalty and silence, girlhood) and argue how the ending reframes it.

Answer key

Answer key: 1. B (Her grandmother, Mrs. Tilley); 2. B (A white heron); 3. C (Ten dollars); 4. A (She climbs a great pine tree at dawn); 5. A (Not to tell the hunter); 6. A (in an irritable, complaining way); 7. B (slow; tending to delay); 8. A (in an irritable, complaining way); 9. B (slow; tending to delay); 10. C (hard to grasp, catch or put into words); 11. D (lingered; hung about); 12. A (call forth (emotions, feelings, and responses))

Essay assignments

Essay: Nature versus progress

Middle School (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2; Indiana 2023: 7.W.1, 7.RC.2): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what A White Heron teaches about nature versus progress. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Sarah Orne Jewett develops nature versus progress in A White Heron. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Sarah Orne Jewett develops nature versus progress across A White Heron. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.3; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of A White Heron (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of nature versus progress. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO5): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of nature versus progress in A White Heron. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; AP: AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Sarah Orne Jewett's choices in A White Heron (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of nature versus progress, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places A White Heron's treatment of nature versus progress in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on nature versus progress in A White Heron that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on nature versus progress in A White Heron. Name your critical

method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about nature versus progress in A White Heron, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on nature versus progress in A White Heron, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Loyalty and silence

Middle School (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2; Indiana 2023: 7.W.1, 7.RC.2): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what A White Heron teaches about loyalty and silence. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Sarah Orne Jewett develops loyalty and silence in A White Heron. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Sarah Orne Jewett develops loyalty and silence across A White Heron. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.3; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of A White Heron (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of loyalty and silence. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO5): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of loyalty and silence in A White Heron. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; AP: AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Sarah Orne Jewett's choices in A White Heron (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of loyalty and silence, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places A White Heron's treatment of loyalty and silence in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on loyalty and silence in A White Heron that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on loyalty and silence in A White Heron. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about loyalty and silence in A White Heron, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on loyalty and silence in A White Heron, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Girlhood

Middle School (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2; Indiana 2023: 7.W.1, 7.RC.2): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what A White Heron teaches about girlhood. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Sarah Orne Jewett develops girlhood in A White Heron. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Sarah Orne Jewett develops girlhood across A White Heron. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.3; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of A White Heron (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of girlhood. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO5): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of girlhood in A White Heron. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; AP: AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Sarah Orne Jewett's choices in A White Heron (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of girlhood, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places A White Heron's treatment of girlhood in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on girlhood in A White Heron that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on girlhood in A White Heron. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about girlhood in A White Heron, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on girlhood in A White Heron, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Original Liber et Libri curriculum. Quotations from the public-domain text. Vocabulary definitions are modern and contextual (curated; based on Princeton WordNet 3.0). Word histories appear only where verified (Online Etymology Dictionary, 2026-10-20); other words are student look-ups. AP and Cambridge entries are our own summaries with links, not College Board or Cambridge text; ICC-WC and LeL IDs are Liber et Libri labels. Included with every curriculum purchase and with Classroom Pro.